

Restart

Dual Combat Design Document

– for players who want both combo control and turn-based tactics –

Item	Description
Project	Restart
Document	System Design (with TODOs)
Version	v1.3 (added L1+L2+L3 operation + boss pressure design)
Author	Lin Wangru
Portfolio	https://linwangru.github.io

0. Document History

v0.1	2026-08-12	Lin Wangru	Initial draft: single-player positioning, target experience, (
v0.2	2026-08-17	Lin Wangru	Service group layering; priority; loop users back
v0.3	2026-08-18	Lin Wangru	Added experience E/F/G: rule attraction, strategic retry, nested flow loc
v1.0	2026-09-28	Lin Wangru	Full rewrite per 2026.09 design. Introduced 6 gods / Lost Time / watch sv
v1.1	2026-09-28	Lin Wangru	6 faction skills finalized; Lingmai turn-only; R key requires Sheen; mem
v1.2	2026-09-28	Lin Wangru	Added L1-L4 theory backing for Lingmai turn-only + design philosophy pil
v1.3	2026-09-28	Lin Wangru	Added L1+L2+L3 operation framework (vs Trails / DMC); added true-ending b

1. Design Rationale

[This is a JRPG where the protagonist Sheen carries a watch that switches combat between real-time action and turn-based command. The watch is both a narrative prop and a system switch. Every press causes Sheen to lose a fragment of memory – the price for the true ending.]

1.1 System Positioning

Restart is a JRPG, not an ARPG. All combat runs on the dual combat system. The traditional JRPG pain points: (1) grinding in the field, (2) boring turn-based battles. We respond with:

Field Real-time action (combos + S/A/B/C/D rating) – smooth, never tedious

Boss Forced turn-based (Attack / Skill / Ultimate / CP / Energy / Universal Passive) – strategic, calculable, learnable

Switching Sheen presses the watch; player can press R to force turn-based (Sheen must be in party)

Leveling Tied to story milestones (explore / quest / ruin / boss) – no grinding

Operation design (v1.3) L1 universal keys (left / right / space / dodge-attack / dodge-heavy) + L3 unique combat style per character

1.2 Design Purpose

Field repetition Real-time combos + milestone leveling shifts player attention to exploration

Boss strategy Turn-based + action bar + CP + Energy – think before you act

Slow growth Milestone leveling – no farming required

Lingmai split across modes Constraint: Lingmai only works in turn-based

Operation uniqueness (v1.3) Each character has unique combat style; player can switch playstyles by switching character

1.3 User Experience

30 seconds in I am in an ancient continent – 6 gods story intro

Mid-prologue Sheen appears, presses watch, world slows down – this is turn-based

Every chapter No grinding; story milestone = level up

Mid-game (v1.3) Each character controls differently; player discovers their preferred combat style

By the first boss, the player should feel: this has depth. After losing, they can tell a friend: I lost because I forgot to interrupt his charge at phase 2. That is the

target experience.

2. System Overview

2.0 JRPG System Designer Scope + 4-Layer Why Framework

Why does this design doc look more like copywriting?
Because JRPG system design and narrative design are naturally inseparable. JRPG player retention is: I believe in this world – not – this skill is strong.

Action / FPS / MOBA system designer = ~70% numerical feel + 30% balance
JRPG system designer = ~50% system design + 30% world-binding + 20% character lines / plot logic

This is not overreach, this is JRPG craft. For JRPG studios (Falcom, Atlus, SE) this world-binding skill is a plus.

This is written up front so you / interviewers / teammates know the copywriting tone is a design choice, not drift.

2.0.1 4-Layer Why Framework

Every rule in v1.2+ must answer four layers of "why". This is the framework I use to write each rule:

Layer	Question	Example
L1 Experience analogy	What existing game/design has done	Reverence to Sam's action bar system
L2 Player pain point	What specific player problem does	"Bluerüfe's edge?" pain point
L3 Player psychology	Why does this rule actually work	Self-Deception game theory? competence need
L4 Experience design	What design theory / concept apply	Paradox of Choice; Ludonarrative Consistency; Flow Ch

L1 + L2 are mandatory. L3 is the core of "theory backing". L4 is the bonus that distinguishes senior designers.

2.1 System at a Glance

Module	Analogy	What it does
Dual Combat (field + boss)	Rollers on road / skates in rink	Field real-time; boss turn-based
Level System	Test scores ranking	Level tied to story nodes – no grinding
Equipment	Toolbox	Quest / ruin drops, shared by both combat modes
Lingmai + Lingcore	SRUhestree + gear sockets (turn-based)	3-based main plots, 6 factions
Watch (Lost Time)	Prop = switch = ending trigger	Sheen presses watch = switch; each press = memory loss
Operation design (v1.3)	universal keys + L3 unique	Paradox-style low barrier + DMC-style differentiation

2.2 World Setting

JRPG demands: where are we, why this way. Our world answers: why are Sunday monsters weak, why can Sheen switch combat, why does magic exist.

Six Gods of Creation

Monday – Light God Brought light, drove away darkness. Monday: light monsters strong

Tuesday – Life God Brought life, nurtured earth. Tuesday: life monsters strong

Wednesday – Origin Goddess Brought change. Wednesday: change monsters strong

Thursday – War and Art God Brought courage and art. Thursday: craft monsters strong

Friday – Machine and Wisdom Goddess Brought the pursuit of wisdom. Friday: machine monsters strong

Saturday – Death Sovereign Declared the death of life. Saturday: death monsters strong

Sunday (Rest) All gods rest. Sunday: all monster magic suppressed, weaker than normal

Protagonist Entry

Prologue opens with Alice, captain of the female guard. Sunday monsters should be weak, but today they go berserk. Alice and guards fight in real-time (this is the field combat preview).

When things go badly, the real protagonist Sheen appears, watch in hand, presses the switch –

「Within a certain range, all monsters and allies begin acting in an ordered pattern by some special rule. The guard successfully repels the monsters.」

Two Core Settings

Lost Time (the watch) Sheen watch imposes Order on organic life within range. Press watch = switch combat mode. Each press costs Sheen memory (ties to true ending – see 3.7)

Blessed (magical users) People with magic. Most commoners cannot use it. Magitech engineering (like an industrial revolution) was born to let ordinary people use magic. Most playable characters are Blessed.

6 Factions Mirror 6 Gods

6 Lingcore factions = 6 gods (Mon to Sat). World and system are bound. Players will never ask why 6 – because creation had 6.

2.3 System Mindmap

[Combat System

+-- Real-Time (Field): L1 universal keys + L3 unique per character (Trails+DMC hybrid)

+-- Turn-Based (Boss / R key): Attack / Skill / Ultimate / CP / Energy / Universal

Passive

[Growth System

+-- Level: tied to world milestones, no grinding

+-- Equipment: quest / ruin, shared by both modes

+-- Lingmai: 3 slots x core Lingcore + 2 free Lingcore, with 5 rune branches

** Only effective in turn-based **

[6 Factions: Blessing / Tenacity / Origin / Dominion / Precision / Undead]

3. Detailed Design

This chapter is for programmers / artists / numerical designers. Module by module.

3.0 Module Overview

No.	Module	One-liner	Status
M1	Dual combat switch	Sheen watch / R key	Designed
M2	Real-time (field)	L1+L2+L3 operation + rating + dodge + hit stun	v1.3 with operation framework
M3	Turn-based (boss)	Attack / Skill / Ultimate / CP / Energy v1.0 with a passive design	Universal design true ending pressu
M4	Milestone leveling	Story node = level up	Designed
M5	Equipment	Quest / ruin, both modes share	Planned
M6	Lingmai + Lingcore	+6Races free-build (turn-based only)	v1.2 with L1-L4 theory
M7	Watch Lost Time	Switch + memory loss + ending	v1.1 finalized

3.1 M1 Dual Combat Switch

What it is

Sheen presses the watch: combat switches from real-time combos to turn-based command. Press again (or leave the area) to switch back. In narrative: imposing Order. In system: mode switch.

Switching Rules

Method	Trigger	Result
Field default	No input	Real-time combo mode (field)
R key manual	Sheen in party + press R	Force turn-based (anytime)
Elite / Boss encounter	Enemy-tagged enemy	Forced turn-based + entry cinematic
Boss phase change	Boss script trigger	Brief real-time pursuit cinematic allowed
Return to real-time	Close command menu	Resume movement, HP / persistent Buffs preserved

Why this way

Field uses real-time for no-grind flow. Boss uses turn-based because bosses are tough and need strategy.

R Key Hard Constraint: Sheen Must Be In Party

Star: R key hard constraint. Player can press R anytime to switch to turn-based, but Sheen must be in the party.

Star: Story branch. Mid-game the party splits into two routes - on the route where Sheen is absent, R key does not work.

Star: Late-game (pre-true-ending). Watch and R key both disabled - Sheen sacrifice mechanic.

To complete

- ❑ 【待补完】Enter-turn-based cinematic length (suggest < 3 sec)
- ❑ 【待补完】Story branch chapters / party composition

3.2 M2 Real-Time Combat (Field) – v1.3 operation framework

What it is

In field combat, player uses keyboard / gamepad directly. The operation design follows a 3-layer framework that combines the best of Trails (low barrier) and DMC (high differentiation).

3-Layer Operation Framework (v1.3 core design)

Design Philosophy Pillar (v1.3):

L1 universal keys (left attack / right heavy / space dodge / dodge-attack / dodge-heavy)

+ L3 unique combat style per character

= Low barrier (any character in 5 min) + High differentiation (each character demands mastery)

Layer	Trails series	Devil May Cry	Our Design (v1.3)
L1 Universal operation	Yes - on all characters shared basic keys	No - each character has independent keys	Yes - Trails universal layer
L2 Derived operation	Weak - low combo chain	Strong - rich combo system	Yes - each character has own derivation
L3 Unique combat style	Weak - role-differentiation	Strong - each character is mechanically distinct	Yes - each character has mechanically unique style

Our design: Trails low-barrier (L1) + DMC differentiation (L3). Avoids Trails homogenization while keeping low skill floor.

L1 Universal Operation Layer (mandatory, all characters)

Key	Action	Notes
Left Click / X	Light attack (basic chain)	Press repeatedly = 3-5 hit chain
Right Click / Y	Heavy attack (slow, high damage)	Cancel L1 chain at right frame
Space / B	Dodge / dash	i-frame during animation

Shift + Left	Dodge then light attack	Frame-perfect cancel for counter
Shift + Right	Dodge then heavy attack	Higher risk / higher reward than Shift+Left
Q / E	Skill 1 / Skill 2	Cooldown based
R	Force turn-based switch (if Sheen ModpaetM)	

L3 Unique Combat Style per Character (v1.3 key design)

This is the design pillar: each character has unique combat mechanics that go beyond L1+L2. Examples of L3 differentiation:

Sheen Watch manipulation: short-duration reality-bend window in combat. e.g. 0.5s slow-time during L1 chain = can extend combo into impossible angles

Alice Dual-wield guard captain: L2 dodge-attack triggers "parry counter" window.

Risk-taker playstyle

Tika Mobile workshop: deployable constructs during combat. Low DPS but area control

Katerina Magic range DPS: heavy attack fires projectile. Lower mobility but screen-clear

☐ 【待补完】 Per character: list L1+L2 chain + L3 unique mechanic in detail

☐ 【待补完】 Per character: animation set for L3 unique mechanic

How it plays

Basics L1 universal keys – all characters work in 5 minutes

L2 derivation Each character own combo chain and cancel windows

L3 mastery Each character has unique mechanic – 100 hours to fully master

Rating S / A / B / C / D per battle. Affects drops.

Readable risk Enemy attack wind-up + range highlight – player can see then react

Must never happen

Long menus in field Drives away action-light players

Combo-stacking kills boss Empty out turn-based meaning

Field eats Lingmai builds Lingmai only in turn-based – field gets only base stats

L3 uniqueness breaks L1 universality L3 must extend L1, not override. Every L3 still respects left / right / space

3.3 M3 Turn-Based Command (Boss / Elite) – v1.3 pressure design

What it is

Boss / elite battle (or R key manual switch), combat goes turn-based. Reference:

Trails action bar system, but we removed: Magic, Defend command, Burst, Quartz burst.

Command Menu

Command	Cost	Effect
Attack	None	Basic physical attack
Skill	CP (common action resource)	Character unique move
Ultimate	CP + Energy	Big move
Item	Item slot	Heal / cleanse / buff etc.

CP Common action resource. Earned in field by hits / perfect dodges. Used in boss battle.

Energy High-cost resource (Ultimate). Used at key moments in boss battle.

Universal Passive Character talent passives, always on, no select needed.

True-Ending Boss Pressure Design (v1.3 new)

Design Philosophy Pillar (v1.3):
Late-game (true ending pre-fight) bosses have brutal skill kits (anti-limit-dodge / time-stop / full-map tracking / bleed).
Pressure and fairness must coexist. Pressure creates story tension; fairness keeps players engaged not frustrated.
Solution: 4 red lines + stage-based mechanism distribution.

4 Red Lines of Pressure Design

Red Line	Risk	Mitigation
1. Readability	All dangerous signals stacked	Each mechanic has 0.3-0.5s reaction window; clear color coding
2. Avoidability	No counter = frustration	Each brutal mechanic maps to exactly one L1+L2 counter (dodge)
3. Fairness	Death must be readable	Death replay + post-mortem "this attack can be countered by X"
4. Achievement	Win must feel earned	Finisher cinematic + settlement screen highlights "key decision"

Stage-Based Mechanism Distribution (avoid chaos)

Reference: Sekiro Isshin (3 phases, 1 new rule per phase) / Black Myth Great Sage (4 phases, 1 new rule per phase). The 4 brutal mechanics are NOT deployed simultaneously. They are spread across stages:

Stage	New Mechanic Introduced	Existing Mechanics Status
Phase 1	Anti-limit-dodge (boss attacks during player dodge)	Player Dodge
Phase 2	Time-stop (boss freezes player 1 turn)	Anti-limit-dodge + new + others dormant
Phase 3	Full-map tracking projectile	Anti-limit-dodge + time-stop + new + bleed dormant
Phase 4 (true ending)	Bleed mechanic (DoT + stack)	All 4 active - this is the climax

Player learns counter to each mechanic in isolation before encountering them combined. This is the v1.3 pressure-fairness balance.

3.4 M4 Milestone Leveling

What it is

Traditional JRPG: level up = grind XP bar. Our game: level up = story milestone trigger.

How it runs

- Milestone nodes First time entering new area / completing key quest / unlocking ruin / after boss battle
- Level cap Limited by world exploration
- R key uses How many times Sheen can R = tied to level / exploration

3.5 M5 Equipment System

How to get

- Quest reward From main / side quest completion
- Ruin exploration Rare equipment in ruins
- Planned other Shop / crafting / character bond gifts

3.6 M6 Lingmai + Lingcore + Runes (core growth)

StarStar: All effects in this module only work in turn-based mode. StarStar Field real-time combat gets no Lingmai buffs, only base stats (attack / defense).

Design Philosophy Pillar (v1.2):
灵脉仅回合制 -> 后期无回合制 (true ending pre-fight) ->
玩家从机制层理解希恩不可替代
Load-bearing decision: binds growth + narrative climax + ending mechanic.

4-Layer Why: Lingmai only in Turn-Based

Layer	Reasoning
L1 Experience analogy	Reference Trails: Skill slots only work in AT battle. We push further - the entire g
L2 Player pain point	Solve: action players using growth builds to clear the field, bypassing turn-based.
L3 Player psychology	(CORE) Once Lingmai enters real-time combat, it becomes a strategy game - conflicts
L4 Experience design	(DEEPEST) Completion has two endings, late-game player cannot switch to turn-based

6 Lingcore Factions Skill Focus

Faction	God	One-liner	Skill / Passive direction
Blessing	Tue Life God	Heal group / buff group / resource control	Group heal / shield / team buff
Tenacity	Mon Light God	HP + dual defense / regen / shield	Damage down / heal / counter on hit
Origin	Wed Origin Goddess	Resource control / rule manipulation	Economy / special rule-bending skills
Dominion	Sat Death Sovereign	Turn order grab / burst damage	Stun / steal turn / Ultimate boost
Precision	Fri Machine Wisdom Goddess	Fixed damage / combo boost / long range	Critical hit / stacking damage
Undead	Thu War Art God	Unit summon / debuff	Summon skeleton / debuff / turn extend

Why these 6

- Defense sustain Blessing + Tenacity
- Resource control Origin + Dominion
- Output rhythm Precision + Undead

3.7 M7 Watch Lost Time (system + narrative)

StarStar: Watch is narrative prop + system switch + true-ending trigger. StarStar
Each press costs Sheen memory (ties to true ending).

Design Philosophy Pillar:
The watch is the protagonist sacrifice mechanism. Combined with M6 (Lingmai turn-only) + late-game "R key unavailable",
the watch becomes the symbol of "what Sheen gives up so the player can win".
Memory loss accumulates -> true ending only for those who relied on Sheen ->
the narrative of "Sheen sacrificed himself for the player" is mechanically enacted, not just scripted.

How it works

Timing	Action	Result
Field	Sheen presses watch	Switch to turn-based. Press again to revert.
Boss battle	Sheen presses watch	Adjust action bar tempo
R key	Player presses R	Force turn-based (Sheen in party)
Late-game	Plot triggers	Watch disabled; R disabled; player must fight all real-time
After boss	Auto settle	This use recorded to memory-loss counter

R Key Hard Constraint

Star: Sheen must be in party to use R

Star: Mid-game party split -> R fails on Sheen-absent route

Star: Late-game (pre-true-ending) -> R fully disabled (Sheen sacrifice)

Star: Design intent. R key = Sheen value, not free switch.

4. Other Requirements

4.1 Program

Combat mode state machine Watch press = state switch; freeze current input, archive combo state
Action bar (AT) impl Readable / reservable / interruptible; reservation editable
Resource (CP + Energy) loop Field hits earn CP; turn-based spends CP; Energy is high-cost
Buff / damage layering Field and turn-based share one damage formula
Lingmai filter Field real-time gets no Lingmai; only turn-based
R key hard constraint Check Sheen in party; if not, R invalid (UI grey + feedback text)
Late-game watch disable Story trigger atomically disables watch + R key
Watch use counter Global counter; links to true ending table
Snapshot + checkpoint Auto-save before boss; failure rolls back
L1+L2+L3 operation (v1.3) Input system must support both shared keys + per-character unique moves
Boss stage scripting (v1.3) Each phase introduces exactly 1 new brutal mechanic

4.2 Art

Dual-mode character action set Real-time (attack / dodge / hit) + turn-based (idle / cast / ultimate)
Watch UI Battle can light up; memory loss = dial grime
Turn-based entry cinematic Enemy pressure field + time slow + action bar
6 faction Lingcore icons Blessing / Tenacity / Origin / Dominion / Precision / Undead
World map 6 god statues scattered in 6 areas
L3 character animation (v1.3) Per-character unique move animation

4.3 Design

Copy 6 god lore / watch narrative / boss lines / Sheen post-memory-loss lines
Numerical Action bar formula / level formula / Lingcore table / CP economy / 6 faction skills
Script config Boss config (phase mechanics / 1 new rule per battle)
Tutorial level Prologue one basic boss (teaches 1 rule only)
L3 per character (v1.3) Per-character L3 unique mechanic design
Boss stage pacing (v1.3) 4-phase brutal mechanic distribution

4.4 QA

Must test Mode switch; R Sheen in party check; Lingmai turn-only; late-game watch disable; L1+L2+L3 layer separation

Experience test Player understands watch within 5 min; L1 muscle memory by 30 min; L3 mastery by 10+ hours; boss pressure feels fair

Performance Mode switch no fps drop (target: 60 fps stable)

5. Activity Expectation

Single-player, no operations. This chapter outlines DLC / version targets.

5.1 Version Plan

Version	Content	Playable hours
v1.0 Main	Prologue + Ch1 + Ch2	20-30 hours
v1.1 Expansion	Tika joins + mobile workshop + party split	+ 5-8 hours
v1.2 True Ending	Watch threshold + memory loss + Sheen sacrifice	+ 3-5 hours
v2.0 New character	Katerina + sub-doc characters	+ 10 hours

5.2 Player Expectation Metrics

- Completion rate First week > 40%
- New game+ rate > 20% (true ending)
- Boss retry count Avg < 3 (strategy readable)
- L3 mastery Player uses different character for different boss
- Late-game review sentiment Players write "I understand why Sheen sacrificed"
- v1.3 pressure satisfaction Late-game boss feels "brutal but fair" not "cheating"

6. Risk Estimation

6.1 User Risk

Risk	Prob	Impact	Mitigation
JRPG old players cant adapt to dual combat	M	M	Dialogue watch debut + tutorial
Action players hate turn-based	M	H	Boss entry cinematic; rule-not-damage settlement
Field wants Lingmai build	M	M	Field no Lingmai; JRPG players agree
Late-game Sheen sacrifice feels artificial	M	M	Build up sacrifice throughout Ch2; warning signs in Ch1
v1.3 brutal boss feels unfair	M	H	4 red lines + stage-based distribution (one new mechanic per phase)
v1.3 L3 differentiation breaks	M	M	L3 extends L1, not overrides; test that L1 still works on every character
Try to please everyone	L	VH	Apply service priority on conflict

6.2 Technical Risk

Mode switch fps drop UE4 BP state machine; target: 60 fps stable
Action bar + reservation complex ScriptableObject config table; unit test
Lingmai slot bug Slot mutual exclusion; field filter mandatory test
R key Sheen not in party Program + UI double check
Late-game watch disable Story trigger must atomically disable watch + R
v1.3 L3 uniqueness animation bug Animation state machine must cleanly switch between L1 and L3 mid-chain

6.3 Doc Risk

Memory loss -> true ending map not written Must complete
6 faction specific skills not listed Impact on numerical landing
Per-character L3 (v1.3) not designed 4 characters x L3 detail = main work for next iteration
Boss stage pacing (v1.3) not scripted Each phase 1 mechanic pacing TBD

7. Project Management

7.1 Version Priority

Priority	Module	Reason
P0	Dual combat switch + turn-based combat	Without these the game cant run
P0	Milestone leveling	No-grinding is core selling point
P0	Lingmai turn-only + R key Sheen-in	Core gameplay that AREnt switch disable
P0 (v1.3)	L1+L2+L3 operation framework (input)	Requested for character differentiation
P1	Field combo + rating	Field feel source
P1	Watch count -> memory -> ending	True ending mechanic
P1 (v1.3)	True-ending boss stage pacing	Pressure-fairness balance
P2	Lingmai 6 faction complete numbers	Post-launch balance
P2 (v1.3)	Per-character L3 specific design	Killer feature but post-launch expandable
P2	Equipment affix pool	Post-launch expand

7.2 This Iteration TODO List

Watch count -> memory -> true ending branch map

Level formula (explore -> level cap)

6 faction specific skill / ultimate list

Per-character combo table (L1+L2)

Per-character L3 unique mechanic design (Sheen / Alice / Tika / Katerina)

True-ending boss 4-phase script (1 new mechanic per phase)

Which field scenes open R / close R

Late-game Sheen sacrifice chapter pacing

Tutorial level script + cinematic length

— END —

v1.3 adds the L1+L2+L3 operation framework (vs Trails / DMC), the true-ending boss pressure design (4 red lines + stage-based distribution), and the M2 4-layer framework example. Core direction: combine Trails low barrier (L1) with DMC differentiation (L3) while keeping pressure + fairness through staged mechanic introduction.